Leader resource · all ten posted studies · NKJV

1 Thessalonians: Charts from the Ten Studies

Every chart from the ten 1 Thessalonians studies, in study order — one section per study, with leader notes on every slide.

The series at a glance (1 of 2)

Studies 1–5

#	Passage	Title	In brief
1	1:1–5	**An Introduction to the Thessalonian Church**	Paul, Silvanus, and Timothy greet a young church already marked by faith, love, and hope.
2	1:6–10	**The Many Faces of the Gospel**	The gospel in person, in proclamation, and in prospect — a transformed life, a spreading testimony, and a certain hope.
3	2:1–12	**Delivering the Gospel**	Paul's own conduct as a messenger — no flattery, no greed, no glory-seeking, only a father's care.
4	2:13–20	**A Successful Life of Service**	The word received as the word of God, suffering imitated well, and a hope that Paul calls his crown.
5	3:1–13	**Facing Tribulation**	Paul sends Timothy to a suffering church, and finds his own life bound up with their standing firm.

The series at a glance (2 of 2)

Studies 6–10

#	Passage	Title	In brief
6	4:1–12	**A Life That Pleases God**	Sanctification, brotherly love, and a quiet, faithful life — the shape of pleasing God day to day.
7	4:13–18	**The Rapture of the Church**	Grief with hope — Christ descends, the dead in Christ rise first, and the church is caught up together.
8	5:1–11	**The Coming of the Lord: A Purifying Hope**	The day of the Lord comes like a thief for the world, but believers are children of the light.
9	5:12–22	**The Coming of the Lord: Exhortations**	Rejoice always, pray without ceasing, give thanks in everything — the will of God for an ordinary week.
10	5:23–28	**'Til We Meet Again**	Paul's closing prayer, blessing, and charge — sanctified wholly, kept blameless, until He comes.

Study 1 of 10 · 1 Thessalonians 1:1–5

An Introduction to the Thessalonian Church

Paul, Silvanus, and Timothy greet a young church already marked by faith, love, and hope — a church secure in God, praised for the source of its activity, and reached by a gospel that came in word, in power and in the life of the messengers.

Paul’s road to Thessalonica

Introduction · Geographical background (Acts 16–18)

A

Lystra & Iconium

Timothy joins the team — Paul and Silas add a young convert

Second journey

B

Troas

The Macedonian call: “Come over and help us”

The Spirit redirects west

C

Philippi

Jail, earthquake, and the jailer: “Believe on the Lord Jesus Christ”

The gospel Paul preached

D

Thessalonica

Three Sabbaths in the synagogue — but he stayed longer

Acts 17:1–9

E

Berea → Corinth

Berea, Athens, then Corinth — where both letters were written

Acts 17–18

Who believed

- Jews and devout Greeks in the synagogue (Acts 17:4)
- Not a few of the leading women

What Paul taught new converts

- Prophecy — Jesus is coming
- And it strengthened them

Three men, one letter

1 Thessalonians 1:1a · I — Paul and His Companions

Paul

The friend, not the apostle

- No title — just “Paul”
- A relationship of mutual love and trust
- Contrast Galatians and Corinthians: “Paul, an apostle”

Silvanus (Silas)

The senior member

- Paul’s chosen partner after the split with Barnabas
- Experience and credibility for the team and the mission

Timothy

The leader in training

- Well spoken of in Lystra and Iconium
- Later sent to Philippi; pastor at Ephesus
- Still in formation here

The absence of the title “apostle” reflects the health of this church. Paul writes as brother, not authority.

An introduction, verse by verse

1 Thessalonians 1:1–5 · Outline points I–III

v.1a	Paul and his companions — no apostolic title needed	**—** Paul writes as brother, not authority
v.1b	To the church … in God the Father and the Lord Jesus Christ	**ἐκκλησία** the local assembly in Thessalonica
v.1c	The greeting — “Grace to you and peace”	**χάρις · εἰρήνη** favor in spite of demerit · shalom
v.2	Thanksgiving joined to intercession — “for you all”	**εὐχαριστοῦμεν** a continuous posture of gratitude
v.3	Work of faith, labor of love, patience of hope	**ἔργον · κόπος · ὑπομονή** all sourced in and directed to Christ
v.4	Beloved brethren — your election by God	**ἐκλογή · ἀγαπητοί** God’s sovereign choosing
v.5	The gospel came in word, power, the Spirit and much assurance	**δύναμις · πληροφορία** divine power · full conviction

The church in God and in Christ

1 Thessalonians 1:1b · II.A–B — The church defined and its identity

A

Any assembly

A secular word — even the worshipers of Diana

Acts 19:32

B

Christ takes it

“On this rock I will build My church”

Matt 16:18

C

Church universal

Every believer from Pentecost to the Rapture

The body of Christ

D

Local assembly

“Tell it to the church” — a congregation

Matt 18:17

E

In Thessalonica

Here: the local church in Thessalonica

1 Thess 1:1

In God the Father

- Security
- Love
- The strength of the Father

In the Lord Jesus Christ

- Lord — the title of deity (Jehovah)
- Jesus — Joshua: salvation, deliverer
- Christ — Messiah, the anointed one

Work of faith, labor of love, patience of hope

1 Thessalonians 1:3 · III.B — The content of the prayer

Work of faith
ἔργον ergou · G2041

- Not busy work — work that results from faith
- Seeking God's will, depending on His power
- Results beyond human expectation

Labor of love
κόπος kopou · G2873

- Stronger than ergon: costly, exhausting toil
- Love for Christ, for each other — and for the lost
- "God so loved the world"

Patience of hope
ὑπομονή hypomonēs · G5281

- Endurance in tribulation
- Active perseverance, not passive waiting
- Produced by hope fixed on Christ

Faith in Christ, love for Christ, endurance looking for Christ — all three have Christ as both their source and their object.

Election: proved to whom?

1 Thessalonians 1:4 · III.C — The core of the prayer

Before God
ἐκλογή eklogē · G1589

- Election is God’s sovereign choosing
- Justification by faith alone
- Abraham believed — Gen 15:6
- My assurance rests on the Word of God

vs

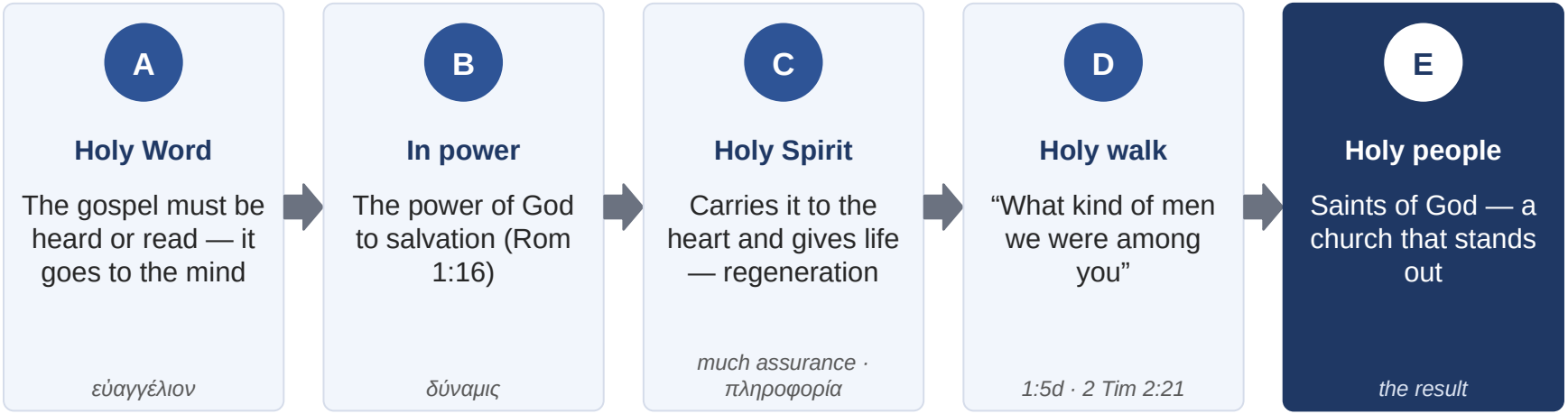
Before men
ἔργον ergon · G2041 · the outworking

- Others know only what they see
- Works are evidence to them (James 2)
- They do not cause election
- Never “faith plus works” for salvation

My works do not prove my election to me — the Word of God does. My works show others what God has already done.

How the gospel came to Thessalonica

1 Thessalonians 1:5 · III.D — The confidence of the prayer



Holy Word + Holy Spirit + holy walk = holy people. We give people the gospel; the Holy Spirit does the rest.

Discuss and apply

1 Thessalonians 1:1–5 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. Why does Paul NOT use the title “Apostle” here, as he does in Galatians and 1 Corinthians?

2. How does “dynamis” (power) differ from ordinary human persuasion, and what role does the Holy Spirit play?

Apply

Examine the Source of Your Activity
Before any ministry this week, pray: “Lord, I am doing this because I trust You, love You, and am looking for You.”

Build an Intercessory Prayer List
Write out people in your church by name and pray through the list at least three times this week.

In one line: A church secure in God, busy from the right source, reached by a gospel that came in word, in power and in a holy life.

Study 2 of 10 · 1 Thessalonians 1:6–10

The Many Faces of the Gospel

The gospel, once truly received, becomes visible in a transformed life, unstoppable in its spread, and certain in its future hope — leaving no room for a merely private, silent, or present-tense faith.

Three faces of one gospel

1 Thessalonians 1:6–10 · Outline I–III

In person · 1:6–7

- They imitated Paul — and the Lord
- Received the word in much affliction
- With joy of the Holy Spirit
- Became an example to others

In proclamation · 1:8–9

- The word “sounded forth” — an echo
- Macedonia, Achaia, every place
- Turned to God from idols
- To serve the living and true God

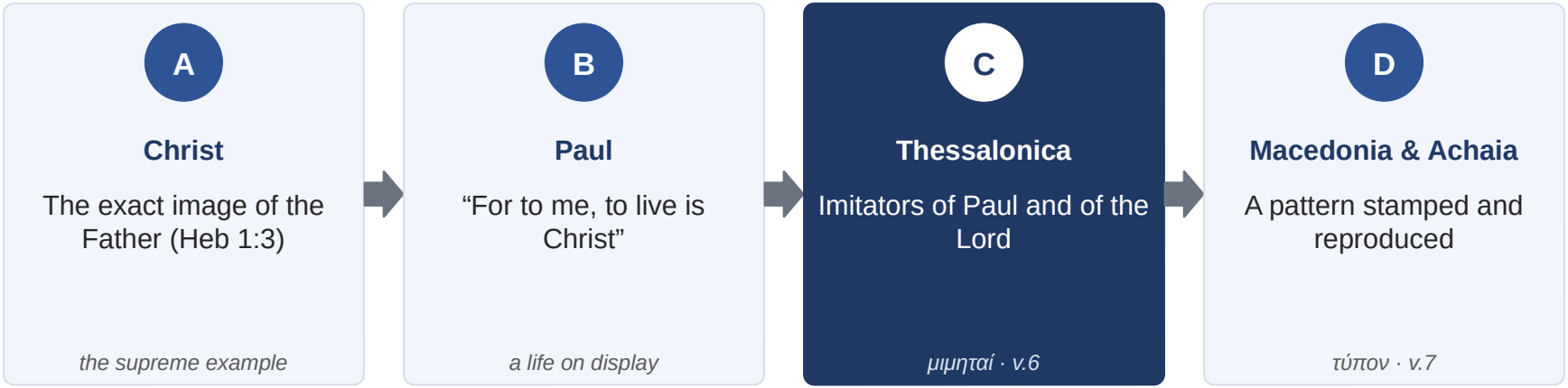
In prospect · 1:10

- Rapture — wait for His Son from heaven
- Resurrection — whom He raised
- Rescue — from the wrath to come

A life worth imitating, a testimony that echoes, a hope that waits. God does not wait for maturity before He produces something worth celebrating.

The chain of imitation

1 Thessalonians 1:6–7 · I.A–B — What they determined and demonstrated



“Imitate me, just as I imitate Christ”

- 1 Cor 11:1 — the chain always ends in Christ
- Paul was a signpost, never the destination

Discipleship is caught as much as taught

- Someone may be imitating you right now
- Would it draw them nearer to Christ?

Joy in much affliction

1 Thessalonians 1:6 · I.A.3–4 — Persecution eclipsed by joy

Happiness		Joy of the Holy Spirit χαρᾶς πνεύματος ἁγίου genitive of source
• Depends on what happens to you • Needs circumstances to cooperate • Cannot survive the climate of affliction	vs	• Rooted in God — the Spirit is its source • Fruit of the Spirit (Gal 5:22) • Grows inside affliction (θλίψει)

The test: “Was God glorified in this?” If yes — or if you know you were walking in obedience — you have the joy of the Holy Spirit, whatever it cost you.

The word sounded forth

1 Thessalonians 1:8–9a · II.A–B — The realm and reach of their witness

A

Thessalonica

On the Via Egnatia, with a busy harbor

a crossroads of the empire

B

Macedonia

Philippi, Amphipolis, Apollonia, Berea

the northern province

C

Achaia

Corinth and the south

Paul writes from Corinth

D

Every place

“We do not need to say anything”

v.8b–9a

ἐξήχηται has sounded forth — an echo still ringing (perfect tense)

An echo doesn’t need to be louder than the original sound to carry it further — only faithful to it.

“You turned to God from idols to serve”

1 Thessalonians 1:9b · II.C — The results of their witness

A common misreading

- Turning from idols was the condition for salvation
- Clean up first, then qualify for grace
- No one still wrestling with an idol could have assurance

vs

What the verse says ✓

ἐπεστρέψατε → δουλεύειν turned → to serve

- Turned to God — living and true
- From idols — what followed necessarily
- To serve — the fruit of salvation, not its price

They didn’t turn from idols to be saved. They turned from idols because they had been saved. Don’t confuse description with condition.

Rapture · Resurrection · Rescue

1 Thessalonians 1:10 · III.A–C — The gospel in prospect

Rapture · 10a
ἀναμένειν to wait for · G362

- “His Son from heaven”
- No sign attached (John 14:3)
- Present tense: a lifestyle of readiness

Resurrection · 10b
“whom He raised” from the dead

- Proof that the “living God” is living
- The hinge the whole hope swings on
- Not aspiration — inheritance

Rescue · 10c
ὀργῆς wrath · G3709

- “Who delivers us from the wrath to come”
- An earthly outpouring — the tribulation
- Removed before it, not through it

Christmas decorations in November tell you Thanksgiving is close — because Thanksgiving always comes first. Signs of the Second Coming tell us the Rapture is close.

Discuss and apply

1 Thessalonians 1:6–10 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. Verse 9 says they “turned to God from idols to serve the living and true God.” Why does the order matter, and why is turning from idols not the condition for salvation?

2. The Thessalonians waited for Christ with no sign attached (1:10). How does a signless, any-moment hope change the way a believer lives day to day?

Apply

Become Someone Worth Imitating

Name one person who may be imitating you, and have one honest conversation about following Christ, not just you.

Live Ready, Not Anxious

Choose one responsibility you’d want to be found tending if Christ returned this week, and give it deliberate attention.

In one line: Live the gospel so it is worth imitating, speak it so it echoes past you, and wait for the Son who is coming.

Study 3 of 10 · 1 Thessalonians 2:1–12

Delivering the Gospel

Paul is not writing autobiography; he is defending his ministry — and in doing so paints a master class in delivering the gospel faithfully. Are you carrying the gospel, or getting in its way?

Delivering the gospel, verse by verse

1 Thessalonians 2:1–12 · Outline I–II

v.1	His coming — not in vain	**κενός** empty — a wasted trip
v.2	His circumstance — beaten at Philippi, bold at Thessalonica	**παρρησιάζομαι** spoke boldly, in the open
vv.3–4	His assertions — no error, uncleanness or deceit; approved and entrusted	**δοκιμάζω · πιστεύω** tested · entrusted
vv.5–6	What he refused — guile, gain and glory	**—** God is witness
vv.7–9	What he revealed and reserved — a mother's love; working night and day	**τροφός** nursing mother
v.10	His attitude — devoutly, justly, blamelessly	**ὁσίως · δικαίως · ἀμέμπτως** a life that matched the message
vv.11–12	His apprehensions — a father's charge: walk worthy of God	**ἀξίως** of equal weight — a balance scale

Where success and failure belong

1 Thessalonians 2:1 · I.A — Paul’s coming

Success belongs to God

- Any fruit is God’s doing — He gets the credit
- The gospel carries its own power
- The messenger cannot manufacture conversion

vs

Failure belongs to man

- To the messenger — if he failed in content or conviction
- To the hearers — if they failed in faith or follow-up
- Not to a faithful messenger whose hearers refuse

“If I go out and witness to ten people and nine reject it, I was not a failure nine times. If I presented the gospel faithfully and didn’t get in God’s way, I am not a failure at all.”

Three ways to corrupt the message

1 Thessalonians 2:3 · II.A.1a — The truth shown

Not from error πλάνη planē · G4106	Nor uncleanness ἀκαθαρσία akatharsia · G167	Nor deceit δόλος dolos · G1388
Content • Not a drifting, untethered teaching • Checked against Scripture — and found true • The gospel is verifiable	**Conduct** • Pagan worship was saturated with immorality • Paul's ministry had none of it • The gospel is pure	**Method** • No traps, no bait • Nothing hidden behind an attractive presentation • No misleading promises

Content, character, method — a messenger can corrupt the gospel at any of the three.

What the gospel promises — and what it doesn’t

1 Thessalonians 2:3 · Free from deceit (misleading promises)

× Off the table		✓ What Paul offered
• “You will be more prosperous.” — you might get fired • “You will be happier.” — some lives got harder • “Your marriage will be better.” — some spouses left	vs	• You will have eternal life • Your sins will be forgiven • A personal relationship with the God of the universe • A home in heaven — a place prepared for you

Don’t make promises the gospel doesn’t make. Don’t withhold the promises it does make.

Approved, entrusted — so we speak

1 Thessalonians 2:4 · II.A.1b–2 — The truth spoken

A

Tested

Assayed in the fire and found genuine

δοκιμάζω

B

Entrusted

Paul trusted God; God trusted Paul with the gospel

πιστεύω — same verb

C

Spoken

“Even so we speak” — three words

2 Cor 5:20 — ambassadors

D

Undisturbed

Not pleasing men, but God who tests our hearts

v.4c

God has believed in you enough to put His gospel in your hands. The Great Commission is not a clergy assignment; it is a whole-church commission.

What Paul refused, revealed and reserved

1 Thessalonians 2:5–9 · II.B — Paul's actions

A — No guile · v.5a

Flattery to manipulate implies the gospel isn't good enough

B — No gain · v.5b

No cloak for covetousness — "God is witness"

C — No glory · v.6

He had an apostle's rights — and chose not to use them

D — A mother's love · v.7

τροφός — a nursing mother gives of her own substance

E — His own life · v.8

Not a hands-on job but an arms-around job

F — Night and day · v.9

He worked so as not to burden them — no one could say he preached for profit

A mother and a father

1 Thessalonians 2:7–12 · II.B.2 and II.D — Two pictures of ministry

A nursing mother · vv.7–8
τροφός trophos · G5162

- Holds, feeds, warms
- Gives of her own substance
- Imparts the gospel and her own life

Before two witnesses · v.10

- Devoutly — ὁσίως
- Justly — δικαίως
- Blamelessly — ἀμέμπτως
- “You are witnesses, and God also”

A father · vv.11–12
παρακαλοῦντες exhorting · G3870

- Exhorted — called alongside
- Comforted — arm around the shoulder
- Charged — testified (μαρτυρόμενοι)

The goal · v.12: “that you would walk worthy (ἀξίως) of God who calls you” — a life that carries the same weight as the calling.

Discuss and apply

1 Thessalonians 2:1–12 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. Paul denies three things in verse 3 — error, uncleanness and deceit. What specific danger does each one represent for a gospel messenger today?

2. Paul uses a nursing mother (v.7) and a father (v.11). What is distinctive about each image, and what would a ministry shaped by both look like in your group?

Apply

Refuse the Three G's
Find one place this week where you'd seek recognition for a spiritual contribution — and deliberately step back.

Impart Not Just the Gospel, But Your Life
Schedule one meal, coffee or visit this month with someone who isn't yet a believer — simply to be present.

In one line: Carry the gospel — don't dilute it, don't exploit it, don't perform it. Just deliver it, and don't get in God's way.

Study 4 of 10 · 1 Thessalonians 2:13–20

A Successful Life of Service

The word received as the word of God, suffering imitated well, and a hope that Paul calls his crown — what is your glory and joy?

Converts, countrymen, crown

1 Thessalonians 2:13–20 · Outline I–III

I · The converts

2:13–14 · Their success

- Welcomed the word as the Word of God
- It keeps working in those who believe
- Followed the Judean churches — in suffering

II · The countrymen

2:15–16 · Their sin

- Killed the Lord and the prophets
- Persecuted Paul; forbade preaching to Gentiles
- Wrath has come upon them

III · The crown

2:17–20 · Its sureness

- Torn away in presence, not in heart
- Hindered by Satan
- “You are our glory and joy”

The success of these converts is not measured in comfort or ease. It is measured in faithfulness under fire.

How they received the Word

1 Thessalonians 2:13 · I.A — Divine authenticity and divine achievement

Divine authenticity · 13a
δέχομαι welcomed · G1209

- Not the word of men — the Word of God
- An active, intentional welcome
- Verbal, plenary inspiration: every word, every part

vs

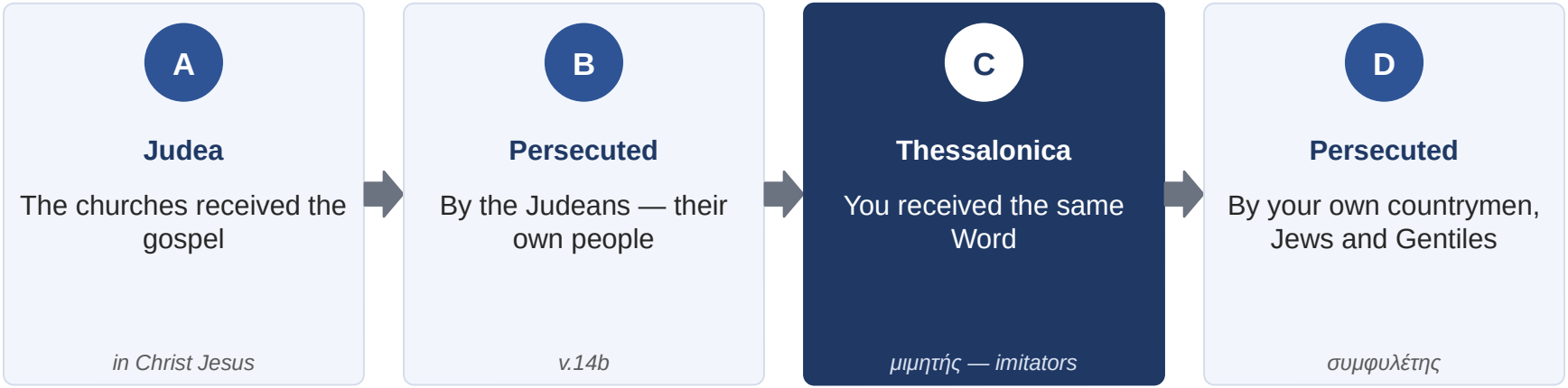
Divine achievement · 13b
ἐνεργέω effectively works · G1754

- Works — present tense, not “worked”
- Ongoing operation in believers
- Discipleship for a lifetime, not only salvation

A word from men can be debated, modified, or ignored. The Word of God demands a response. It carries authority.

Imitators — in consequence

1 Thessalonians 2:14 · I.B — How they acted on the Word



They heard the Word, believed the Word, acted on the Word — and paid for it with suffering. That is the mark of genuine reception: faithful reception produces a predictable result — not comfort, but conflict.

The sin of Paul’s countrymen

1 Thessalonians 2:15–16 · II.A–E — Five expressions

A **Provocation · 15a**

Killed the Lord Jesus and their own prophets, and persecuted Paul

B **Presumption · 15b**

“They do not please God” — they pleased themselves

C **Perversity · 15c**

“Contrary to all men” — the gift used as a wall, not a door

D **Prejudice · 16a**

Forbidding the gospel to the Gentiles “that they may be saved”

E **Punishment · 16b**

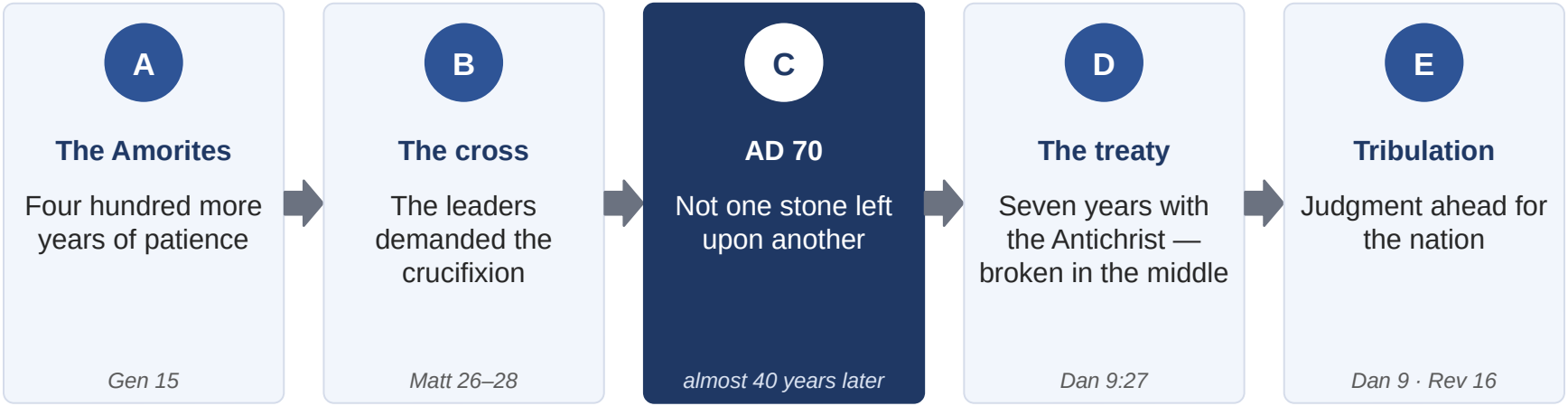
“To fill up the measure” — wrath has come upon them

Gk **ἀναπληρόω · G378**

God’s patience is real, but it has a limit — His justice is as certain as His grace

“Wrath has come” — as certain as if done

1 Thessalonians 2:16b · II.E — Their punishment



Romans 8:30 logic: “whom He justified, these He also glorified.” Are you glorified yet? No — but it is as certain as if it had already happened. So is this wrath.

Torn away, hindered, rewarded

1 Thessalonians 2:17–20 · III.A–B — Paul's desire and delight

v.17	Taken away in presence, not in heart	**ἀπορφανίζω** orphaned — torn from his children
v.18	Satan hindered us — though not everything is Satan's fault (James 1)	**ἐγκόπτω** cut the path — strategic opposition
v.19a	Our hope, joy, crown — at the judgment seat of Christ	**στέφανος** the victor's wreath — people won
v.19b	"In the presence of our Lord Jesus Christ at His coming"	**παρουσία** here, the Rapture
v.20	"For you are our glory and joy"	**δόξα** they reflect what God did

Use things and love people

1 Thessalonians 2:19–20 · Conclusion — John Phillips

Solomon		David — and Paul
• A good start • Rejoiced in women, power and riches • Loved things and used people • A colossal failure in God’s eyes	vs	• A mid-life failure — and repentance (Ps 51) • Served God faithfully • Used things and loved people • Paul: people as crowns laid at Jesus’ feet

“Only one life will soon be past; only what’s done for Christ will last.” What is your glory and joy?

Discuss and apply

1 Thessalonians 2:13–20 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. The Word “effectively works” (energeō) in believers — present tense, ongoing. What does this say about the role of Scripture beyond the moment of salvation?

2. The sermon contrasts Solomon and David. What does Paul’s crown (stephanos) reveal about what he truly valued?

Apply

Receive the Word as the Word of God

Before your next time in the Word, pray: “Lord, I receive this as Your Word, not a man’s word. Let it work in me.”

Use Things and Love People

Name one person whose growth in Christ you are investing in — or ask God this week to show you who it should be.

In one line: The Word received as God’s Word keeps working, will cost something — and the people we serve become our crown.

Study 5 of 10 · 1 Thessalonians 3:1–13

Facing Tribulation

Paul sends Timothy to a suffering church — to establish and encourage them — and finds his own life bound up with their standing firm.

From Berea to Corinth

Introduction · The background in Acts 17–18

A

Berea

Paul forced to leave; brothers escort him

Acts 17

B

Athens

Paul stays alone; sends Timothy back

3:1–2

C

Thessalonica

Timothy establishes and encourages the church

3:2–5

D

Corinth

Silas and Timothy find Paul (Acts 18:5)

Timothy's report · 3:6

E

The letter

Written from Corinth, looking back

1 Thessalonians

Paul could scarcely bear not knowing how they were doing. They had endured all kinds of tribulation; he had been chased out. So he sent Timothy back to find out how the young church was making out.

Why Timothy — and why he went

1 Thessalonians 3:2 · I.B — The proposal

The messenger chosen
διάκονος minister · G1249

- Our brother
- Minister of God
- Fellow laborer in the gospel

A full commendation for a young man — someone the church already knew and trusted.

The messenger charged

1. **To establish — στηρίζω**
   Make them firm: the faith believed (Jude 3) and their trust in it

2. **To encourage — παρακαλέω**
   Come alongside them in their afflictions, as the Paraclete does

3. **The two great needs**
   Something solid to stand on, and someone to stand with them

What the minister begins (stērizō, v.2), God completes (stērizō, v.13).

Appointed to this

1 Thessalonians 3:3–5 · I.C–D — The petition and the plan

Not shaken · v.3

σαίνω · κεῖμαι shaken · appointed

- Not “no tribulation” — but not shaken by it
- “We are appointed to this”
- Part of the calling, not a surprise

Foretold · v.4

- “We told you before” — again and again
- Taught before persecution came
- “Just as it happened, and you know”

The tempter · v.5

πειράζω to tempt · G3985

- No news is not good news
- Satan uses suffering to erode faith
- “Lest our labor might be in vain”

Suffering is not evidence that God has abandoned us; it is the predictable consequence of faithful gospel reception in a hostile world.

Good news from Thessalonica

1 Thessalonians 3:6–10 · II.A–C — Paul's consolation

v.6	Timothy's report: your faith and love; you long to see us	**εὐαγγελίζω** news as good as the gospel
v.7	In all our affliction we were comforted by your faith	**παρακαλέω** comfort is a two-way street
v.8	"For now we live, if you stand fast in the Lord"	**στήκω** their firmness, his vitality
v.9	What thanks can we render to God for you — all the joy	**—** God gets the credit
v.10	Praying night and day, exceedingly, to see you and complete your faith	**καταρτίζω** bring to full strength

Paul’s prayer: love, holiness, readiness

1 Thessalonians 3:11–13 · III.A–C — Paul’s craving

A

Direct our way

Father and Son named — one singular verb

v.11 · optative

B

Abound in love

To one another and to all — overflowing

περισσεύω · v.12

C

Hearts established

Blameless in holiness before God

ἀμέμπτως · v.13a

D

At His coming

With all His saints

παρουσία · v.13b

Love produces holiness; holiness makes the heart blameless at the coming of the Lord.

Blameless does not mean sinless — free of any reasonable charge, because sin is dealt with as God requires.

Coming for His saints — coming with them

1 Thessalonians 3:13b · III.C.2 — The return of the saints with the Lord

For His saints — the Rapture		With His saints — 3:13 παρουσία coming · G3952
• Christ comes for His church (4:13–18) • The dead in Christ rise; the living are caught up • Signless — at any moment	vs	• The public, triumphant Second Coming • The saints who have gone to be with Christ come with Him • Christians, not angels

Paul’s prayer is that when that day arrives, these believers would be found blameless — hearts established, lives marked by the holiness that comes from abounding love.

Discuss and apply

1 Thessalonians 3:1–13 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. Verse 3 says believers are “appointed” to tribulation (keimai). What does this mean for how we interpret suffering — and how does it change our response?

2. Verse 8 says “we live, if you stand fast in the Lord.” Is this hyperbole, or does Paul mean it? What does it reveal about pastoral ministry?

Apply

Expect Tribulation; Prepare Others

Have one honest conversation with a younger believer about suffering — share verse 3: “we are appointed to this.”

Your Faithfulness Is a Lifeline

Message someone whose faith has strengthened you and tell them specifically what their steadfastness has meant.

In one line: Tribulation is part of the calling — so establish one another, stand fast together, and let love grow into holiness until He comes.

Study 6 of 10 · 1 Thessalonians 4:1–12

A Life That Pleases God

A life that pleases God is not produced by rules or resolutions, but by the outworking of four God-given realities: our potential, our purity, our progress, and our purpose.

Four God-given realities

1 Thessalonians 4:1–12 · Outline I–IV

Potential · 4:1–2

- What is committed to us
- Received and repeated — practiced
- The commandments of the Lord Jesus

Purity · 4:3–8

- Sanctification is God’s will
- Abstain from sexual immorality
- A sin against Father, Son and Spirit

Progress · 4:9–10

- Taught by God to love
- Already loving all Macedonia
- “Increase more and more”

Purpose · 4:11–12

- A quiet life
- Mind your own business; work
- Walk properly before outsiders

The Christian life is not a set of prohibitions to be avoided. It is an outworking of a loving desire to please God. That’s it.

“We urge you … more and more”

1 Thessalonians 4:1–2 · I — Our potential

v.1	“Finally” — the hinge from doctrine to daily life	**Λοιπὸν** from now on — not “the end”
v.1	“We urge you” — not a command but earnest pleading	**παρακαλοῦμεν** we beg — same root as Paraclete
v.1	“Abound more and more” — the standard is overflow	**περισσεύητε** a river breaching its banks
v.1b	“Just as you received from us” — the old truths, repeated and practiced	**—** “Practice, man, practice”
v.2	“The commandments we gave you through the Lord Jesus”	**—** taught in a few months, c. AD 51

Three phases of sanctification

1 Thessalonians 4:3 · II.A.1 — The need for sanctification

A

From the penalty

At salvation — positional, permanent and complete

past

B

From the power

An ongoing process in this life — Paul's focus here

present · progressive

C

From the presence

At death or the Rapture — changed, like Him (1 Cor 15)

future

ἁγιασμός — sanctification

- Set apart to God from the world
- Appears in vv.3, 4 and 7

πορνεία — sexual immorality

- All sexual sin outside marriage
- Then condoned — even in worship

A sin against the whole Godhead

1 Thessalonians 4:3–8 · II.A–C — Our purity

Against the Father · vv.3–5
σκεῦος vessel · the body

- God’s will: your sanctification
- Control your own body
- Not like the Gentiles who don’t know God

Against the Son · v.6
ὑπερβαίνειν to overstep

- Going beyond the boundary
- Defrauding a brother — πλεονεκτεῖν
- The Lord is the avenger — ἔκδικος

Against the Spirit · vv.7–8
ἁγιασμός called in holiness

- Not called to uncleanness
- Rejecting this is rejecting God
- Who has given us His Holy Spirit

When God says do this, or do not do this, He has already given us the ability to obey. We cannot say, “I can’t do it.”

In Adam or in Christ

1 Thessalonians 4:7 · II.C.1 — The rule

In Adam		In Christ
• Controlled by the Fall • Uncleanness — by natural birth • The natural man delights in vileness	vs	• Controlled by the Call • Holiness — by the new birth • The new man delights in virtue • The Spirit is in us (1 Cor 6:19–20)

John Phillips: “In Adam we are controlled by the fall; in Christ we are controlled by the call.” You are called by a holy God — therefore be holy.

Taught by God to love

1 Thessalonians 4:9–10 · III — Our progress



Love explained · v.9

θεοδίδακτοι taught by God

- φιλαδελφία — family love, planted at the new birth
- Taught by the cross and the Spirit

Love executed · v.10

- Toward all the brethren in all Macedonia
- Commended — not corrected
- “Increase more and more”

A quiet, working, watched life

1 Thessalonians 4:11–12 · IV — Our purpose

v.11a	Aspire to lead a quiet life — settled, not frantic	**ἡσυχάζειν** not silence but settledness
v.11b	Mind your own business	— MYOB — Paul used it first
v.11c	Work with your own hands — Jesus may come today; keep your job	— Paul's self-supporting model
v.12a	Walk properly toward those who are outside	— your walk commends the gospel
v.12b	That you may lack nothing	— plan ahead · work hard · live within your means

Discuss and apply

1 Thessalonians 4:1–12 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. Paul opens with parakalō (urge/beg) rather than a command. What does that tone of pleading tell us about the nature of the Christian life?

2. Paul says the Thessalonians are “taught by God” to love (theodidaktoi, v.9). How does God teach love — and what does that mean for what we expect of ourselves?

Apply

Live to Please God, Not the Crowd
Name one choice you make mainly to please someone else; ask what it looks like with God as the audience.

Love Is Taught by God — Then Practiced
Do one concrete, personal, unpublicized thing this week for someone you haven’t recently shown love to.

In one line: Please God — not by rules but by overflow: set apart to Him, loving more and more, living quietly and well before a watching world.

Study 7 of 10 · 1 Thessalonians 4:13–18

The Rapture of the Church

Grief with hope — Christ descends, the dead in Christ rise first, and the church is caught up together. People looking for the undertaker ought to be looking for the upper-taker.

Israel and the Church

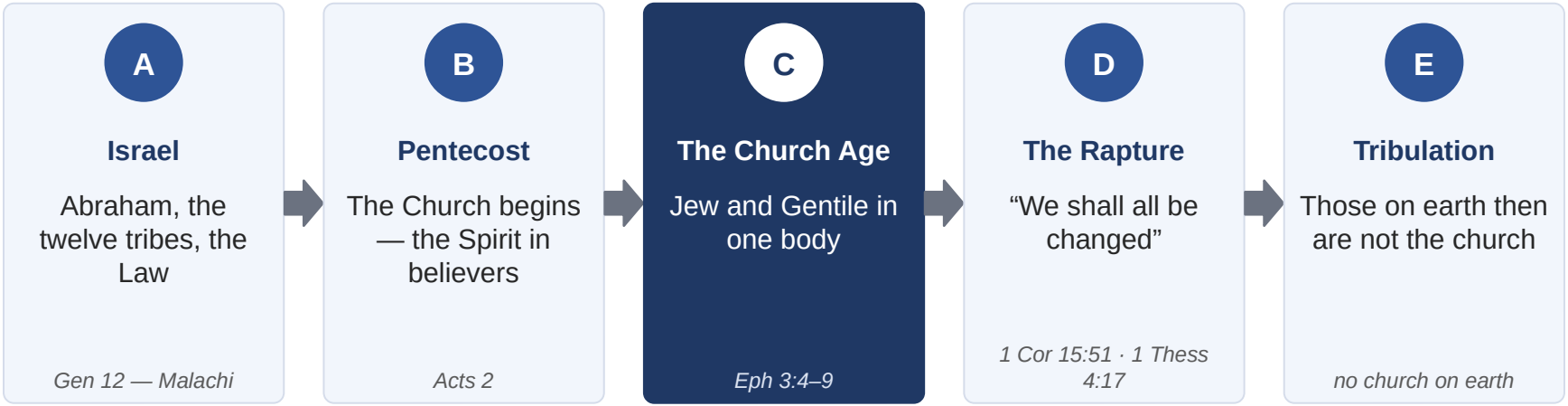
I.A–B · The theological setting

Israel — the Old Testament		The Church — a mystery
• From the call of Abraham (Gen 12) • The Old Covenant — the Law • Physical promises: a land, a kingdom • A literal 1,000-year reign of Christ	≠	• From Pentecost to the Rapture • The New Covenant (Heb 7–10) • Spiritual promises • “Christ in you, the hope of glory” (Col 1:26)

Israel is not — in any way — the Church. The Church is not — in any way — Israel. The Church was hidden in God (Eph 3:9), not in the Old Testament.

The Church on the timeline

I.B · Pentecost to the Rapture



There was no church on earth before Acts 2 at Pentecost. And there will be no church on earth after the Rapture. It is a unique entity in the plan of God.

Where are the believers who have died?

1 Thessalonians 4:13–14 · II.A — A preview

The body sleeps
κοιμάω to sleep · G2837

- In the grave, an urn, the ocean
- Sleep ends with waking
- “The dead in Christ will rise first” (v.16)

+

The soul is with the Lord
ἄγω will bring · G71

- Absent from the body, present with the Lord (2 Cor 5:8)
- “Far better” (Phil 1:23)
- Comes down with Him (v.14)

“Since we believe that Jesus died and rose again” — a first-class condition. If He rose, they rise. We sorrow, but not as others who have no hope (ἐλπίς).

The Rapture, verse by verse

1 Thessalonians 4:13–18 · II.A–C — Preview, promise, picture

v.13	Don’t be uninformed; don’t grieve as those without hope	**κοιμάω · ἐλπίς** asleep, not lost
v.14	Since Jesus died and rose, God will bring them with Him	**ἄγω** will bring — purposeful motion
v.15	By the word of the Lord: the living will not precede the dead	**φθάνω · παρουσία** no believer gets there first
v.16a	The Lord Himself descends — shout, archangel, trumpet	**κέλευσμα** a commanding shout
v.16b	The dead in Christ will rise first	**—** they are going ahead
v.17	Caught up together to meet the Lord in the air	**ἁρπάζω · ἀπάντησις** sudden taking · to meet
v.18	Therefore comfort one another with these words	**παρακαλέω** the doctrine’s purpose

Three sounds at one moment

1 Thessalonians 4:16 · II.C.1 — The resurrection

The shout
κέλευσμα keleusma · G2752

- Only here in the NT
- A shouted order: hunter to hounds
- Lazarus was called by name — this shout has none

The archangel's voice
ἀρχάγγελος archangelos · G743

- Ruler of angels
- Scripture names one: Michael
- Jude 9; Rev 12:7

The trumpet of God
σάλπιγξ salpinx · G4536

- A summons, an assembly, a King's arrival
- All three converge here

"Come forth" — addressed to every believer who has ever died. The dead in Christ will rise first.

Five marks of a comforting truth

1 Thessalonians 4:18 · II.C.3 — The reassurance (John Phillips)

A **Positive truth**

“Shall” — not a possibility; a certainty

B **Personal truth**

We, us, I, you — addressed to individuals

C **Pivotal truth**

“But” (v.13) marks a turn: don’t be ignorant

D **Progressive truth**

“For” links each verse to the next

E **Practical truth**

“Therefore” — applied at once

✓ **παρακαλέω · v.18**

“Comfort one another” — the Spirit’s own ministry

Discuss and apply

1 Thessalonians 4:13–18 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. Verse 14 says God will bring with Him those who sleep in Jesus; verse 16 says the dead in Christ rise first. How can both be true — and what does it teach about body and soul at death?

2. Paul expected to be alive at the Rapture (“we who are alive”). What is the practical effect of living with that expectation — and how does it differ from speculating about dates?

Apply

Hold the Blessed Hope
Begin each morning this week with one sentence: “The Lord may come today.” Notice what it changes.

Comfort One Another
Reach out to one grieving or discouraged person with a verse from this passage and a personal word.

In one line: The dead in Christ are not lost — they rise first, we are caught up together, and we will always be with the Lord.

Study 8 of 10 · 1 Thessalonians 5:1–11

The Coming of the Lord: A Purifying Hope

The day of the Lord comes like a thief for the world, but believers are children of the light — and the hope of His coming is a purifying hope.

The Rapture and the Day of the Lord

Introduction · Two separate events

A

The Rapture

The church taken out — no signs need occur first

4:13–18

B

The treaty

The Antichrist's seven-year treaty with Israel

Dan 9:27 · "Peace and safety!"

C

The midpoint

The mask comes off — sudden destruction

about 3½ years in

D

Second Coming

Christ returns to the earth to deliver His people

end of the seven years

E

The Millennium

His thousand-year reign

the blessing

The Day of the Lord

- Judgment — seven years
- Blessing — one thousand years

"A thief in the night" · 5:2

- Describes the Day of the Lord
- Not the Rapture

Seven features of the coming Day

1 Thessalonians 5:2–3 · Introduction — and a key to the chapter

A — Secret

“Like a thief in the night”

B — Unexpected

While they cry “Peace and safety!”

C — Sudden

Striking without warning

D — Destructive

Catastrophic judgment

E — Inevitable

Nothing can prevent it

F — Irreversible

As labor pains — ὠδίν

G — Inescapable

“They shall not escape”

✓ — Pronoun key

You / we = believers · they / them = unbelievers

Sons of the day, sons of the night

1 Thessalonians 5:1–8 · I — Some differences

They / them — of the night	vs	You / we — of the day **υἱός** sons of light · G5207
• Follow Satan’s deception: “Peace and safety!” • Asleep — spiritually unaware • Drunk — aware, but unable to respond • Sudden destruction; they shall not escape		• Follow Scripture — they know “perfectly” • Not in darkness: the Day won’t overtake them • Watch — γρηγορέω; be sober — νήφω

The “sleep” of 5:6 is not the sleep of 4:13. There, physical death — a comfort word. Here, spiritual lethargy — a warning word.

The armor of the day

1 Thessalonians 5:8 · I.B.2 — The Lord's people

Breastplate of faith θώραξ breastplate · G2382	… and of love θώραξ breastplate · G2382	Helmet: hope of salvation περικεφαλαία helmet · G4030
Inward protection • Keeps us obedient • Keeps us trusting	**Outward protection** • Keeps us from shunning others • Keeps us from neglecting others	**Protects the mind** • Temptation always starts in the mind • Guards against despair, doubt, distraction

Martin Luther: "I cannot keep birds from flying over my head, but I can keep them from making a nest in my hair."

Not appointed to wrath

1 Thessalonians 5:9–11 · II — Some deductions

A

Not to wrath

The Tribulation's wrath — not eternal condemnation

ὀργή · v.9a

B

To salvation

Through our Lord Jesus Christ — by the Rapture

v.9b

C

Wake or sleep

Alive or dead at His coming — we live together with Him

v.10

D

Therefore comfort

Comfort and build up one another

παρακαλέω · οἰκοδομέω

This is a purifying prophecy. The imminent return of Christ makes us want to work for Him today — to watch instead of sleep, to stay sober instead of drunk on this world's distractions, and to comfort one another. We are the Thessalonians.

Discuss and apply

1 Thessalonians 5:1–11 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. The sermon distinguishes the Rapture from the Day of the Lord. What is the difference, and why does it matter for reading this passage?

2. What is the difference between the “sleep” in 4:13 and the “sleep” in 5:6?

Apply

Put On the Armor and Keep It On
Each morning, name what you’re trusting God for, one person you’ll love that day, and the hope of your salvation.

Rest in Your Appointment
Memorize 5:9: “For God did not appoint us to wrath, but to obtain salvation through our Lord Jesus Christ.”

In one line: Not appointed to wrath but to salvation — so watch, stay sober, wear the armor, and comfort one another.

Study 9 of 10 · 1 Thessalonians 5:12–22

The Coming of the Lord: Exhortations

From the sweet by-and-by back to the nasty now-and-now: rejoice always, pray without ceasing, give thanks in everything — the will of God for an ordinary week.

Three sets of instructions

1 Thessalonians 5:12–22 · Outline I–III

To those who are led · 12–13

- Recognize your leaders
- Esteem them very highly in love
- Be at peace among yourselves

To those who lead · 14–15

- Warn, comfort, uphold, be patient
- Never evil for evil
- Always pursue the good

To the whole church · 16–22

- Rejoice · pray · give thanks
- Don’t quench the Spirit or despise prophecy
- Test · hold fast · abstain

The coming of the Lord thrills our souls. Obeying the Lord fills our souls. These exhortations are the proof of whether we believe what we have heard.

Marks of a good leader

1 Thessalonians 5:12–13 · I.A–C — Instructions to those who are led

They toil
κοπιάω kopiaō · G2872

- Hard work to the point of weariness
- A full day's job — then the church

They take charge
προΐστημι proistēmi · G4291

- They "stand before you"
- Good leaders don't hide — they lead from out front

They train
"in the Lord" in a truly Christian way

- Training the people to do the work of the Lord

Esteem them very highly (ἡγέομαι) — in agapē love, for their work's sake. You don't have to like the way a pastor combs his hair. Not personality — faithfulness. And "be at peace": maintain the peace you already have.

Four people, four responses

1 Thessalonians 5:14 · II.A — Help these people

A — Warn the disorderly

ἄτακτος — broke rank: idle, waiting for the Lord (2 Thess 3:6–8)

B — Comfort the fainthearted

ὀλιγόψυχος — the little-souled: grief, fear, intimidation

C — Uphold the weak

Morally or spiritually weak — bear them up, hold them steady

D — Be patient with all

Long-suffering — as patient as God has been with you

Warning the fainthearted would crush them; comforting the disorderly would enable them. Good leadership diagnoses before it responds.

Three levels of response

1 Thessalonians 5:15 · II.B — Hold these principles

A

Evil for evil

Human — natural instinct; it requires no grace

cut off in traffic

B

Evil for good

Devilish — someone does you good, you do them evil

never

C

Good for evil

Divine — where we must be, with anyone

heaps coals of fire

Prohibit this · Pursue this: “See that no one renders evil for evil to anyone, but always pursue what is good both for yourselves and for all.”

The will of God in Christ Jesus for you

1 Thessalonians 5:16–18 · III.A–C — Rejoice, pray, give thanks

Always praise · v.16
χαίρω rejoice · G5463

- Shortest verse in Greek — 14 letters
- Joy is the Christian's flag: the King is in residence

Without ceasing, pray · v.17
ἀδιαλείπτως without ceasing · G89

- Like a hacking cough — all through the day
- Stated times, like Daniel — and staying in touch

In all things, appreciate · v.18

- In everything — every circumstance
- Thank Him for what He has already done
- Even while praying for change

"For this is the will of God in Christ Jesus for you." What is God's will for my life? Start there.

Say yes — and test everything

1 Thessalonians 5:19–22 · III.D–H

v.19	Do not quench the Spirit — say yes to God	**σβέννυμι** throwing water on a fire
v.20	Do not despise prophecies — checked by others (1 Cor 14:29)	— now: the completed Scriptures
v.21a	Test all things — by the written Word of God	**δοκιμάζω** put it to the fire of the Word
v.21b	Hold fast what is good — tested truth is the church's treasure	— grip it; don't let it slip
v.22	Abstain from every form of evil	**εἶδος** every form evil actually takes

Discuss and apply

1 Thessalonians 5:12–22 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. Verse 14 addresses the disorderly, the fainthearted, the weak and those who are different. What does it tell us about pastoral ministry that one response doesn't fit all four?

2. Paul says rejoicing, praying and giving thanks are "the will of God in Christ Jesus for you." How does that change how you approach those three things?

Apply

Return Good for Evil, Every Time
Do one specific, unrequested good thing this week for someone who has wronged you — and tell no one.

Rejoice, Pray, Give Thanks
For seven days: one sentence of rejoicing, one minute of prayer, one expression of thanks each morning.

In one line: While we wait, we still live here: honor your leaders, care wisely for one another, return good for evil, and live God's stated will.

Study 10 of 10 · 1 Thessalonians 5:23–28

’Til We Meet Again

Paul’s farewell is not merely a closing — it is a benediction, a commission, and a promise: the God who called you is faithful, and He will finish what He started in you.

Six parting words

1 Thessalonians 5:23–28 · Outline I–VI

A **Mediation · v.23**

“May the God of peace Himself sanctify you completely”

B **Declaration · v.24**

“He who calls you is faithful, who also will do it”

C **Application · v.25**

“Brethren, pray for us” — three words

D **Reception · v.26**

A holy greeting — nobody leaves unrecognized

E **Exhortation · v.27**

Read to all — the Word must reach everyone (ἐνορκίζω)

F **Benediction · v.28**

“The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ be with you”

Three aspects of sanctification

1 Thessalonians 5:23 · I.A–C — from 1 John 3:2–3

A

Our past

“Now we are children of God” — positional, permanent

1 John 3:2a

B

Our promised

“We shall be like Him, for we shall see Him as He is”

1 John 3:2b

C

Our present

“Everyone who has this hope … purifies himself”

1 John 3:3 · Paul’s emphasis

ἁγιάσαι to sanctify — aorist: the work seen whole · optative: a prayer, not a prediction

Can we see Jesus now? Yes — on the pages of Scripture. Beholding Him, we are being transformed (2 Cor 3:18).

Spirit, soul and body — wholly

1 Thessalonians 5:23 · I.C — Our present sanctification

Spirit — vertical
πνεῦμα pneuma · G4151

- The part that communicates with God
- Only human beings have it

Soul — horizontal
ψυχή psychē · G5590

- Our relationships with others
- How we love, serve and carry one another

Body — the instrument
σῶμα sōma · G4983

- The means by which we do it all
- Sanctified to God, used by God

ὁλοτελεῖς wholly — “completely to the end” · found only here in the New Testament

Walvoord: “Our physical bodies, our spiritual or intellectual life, and our psychological or natural life are all part of this sanctification process.”

“He who calls you is faithful”

1 Thessalonians 5:24 · II — A parting declaration

What we cannot do	What God does πιστός · καλῶν faithful · calling	What we must do
• Sanctify ourselves • Be totally sanctified in this life	• He is faithful — covenant dependability • He keeps calling (present tense) • He will do it	• Make ourselves available • Stop resisting • Behold Him in the Word (2 Cor 3:18)

Philippians 2:12–13: “It is God who works in you both to will and to do for His good pleasure.” He makes your willer will and your doer do.

Grace at both ends

1 Thessalonians 1:1 and 5:28 · VI — A parting benediction

A

1:1

“Grace to you and peace”

the first word

B

Chapters 1–3

What God has done among them

inside the envelope

C

Chapters 4–5

Commands, corrections, calls to holiness

grace in action

D

5:28

“The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ be with you”

the last word

The angels who sinned	vs	Fallen man
• Saw God’s power and justice — never His grace		• God sacrificed His own Son — grace

Discuss and apply

1 Thessalonians 5:23–28 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. The commentary finds three aspects of sanctification in 1 John 3:2–3 — past, promised and present. How does holding all three prevent thinking we are already perfect — or that we must make ourselves perfect?

2. The letter begins with grace (1:1) and ends with grace (5:28). How does grace as the frame shape how we read every command and correction in between?

Apply

Make Yourself Available

Name the one area where you've been pulling back from God, take one step of yielding, and tell someone.

Live from Grace — Not toward It

As a group, write one sentence: what God has done among you through 1 Thessalonians. Post it.

In one line: He who calls you is faithful and will do it — grace at the start, grace at the end. Here, there, or in the air.

Conclusion · 1 Thessalonians 1–5

Here, there, or in the air

A church secure in God, a gospel that echoes, a Word that keeps working, a hope that purifies — all inside the envelope of grace. “He who calls you is faithful, who also will do it.”